DRAFT

Fire Extinguisher Check and Use

Know where the extinguisher is, what it can put out, and whether it appears ready—before an emergency.

△ CAUTION — PREVENT HARM

The device label controls. Extinguisher classifications, operating steps, inspection details, limits, and service lives vary. Read and follow the label and manufacturer instructions for the exact unit. If they differ from this handout, follow the device.

FIND AND IDENTIFY THE EXTINGUISHER

1. **Locate it:** It should be mounted or stored where it is visible, easy to reach, and not blocked. Do not move it from its designated location except for use or service.

2. **Read the front label:** Find the listed fire classifications and pictograms. Use it only on a fire type the label says it can extinguish. Common U.S. labels may show **A** (ordinary combustibles), **B** (flammable liquids), **C** (energized electrical equipment), **D** (combustible metals), or **K** (cooking oils/fats)—but the markings on this extinguisher decide.

3. **Read all instructions:** Find its operating directions, warnings, effective range, and any maintenance or disposal directions. Know whether the unit is rechargeable or disposable. Never test-discharge it during a visual check.

MAKE A MONTHLY VISUAL CHECK

A visual check does not replace maintenance or service required by the manufacturer, local rules, or the authority having jurisdiction.

- ☐ **Access:** unit is in its assigned place, visible, unobstructed, and securely mounted.
- ☐ **Pressure/readiness:** gauge or indicator—if fitted—is in the label's operable range.
- ☐ **Pin and seal:** pull pin is present; tamper seal is intact; nothing prevents operation.
- ☐ **Hose/nozzle:** attached, unobstructed, and free of cracks or other visible damage.
- ☐ **Body and label:** no leakage, corrosion, dents, or other damage; label is present and readable.

Do not use a questionable unit. If a check fails—or the extinguisher was discharged, even briefly—mark the issue and arrange qualified service or replacement according to its label and local requirements.

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Fire Extinguisher Check and Use — continued

RECORD THE CHECK

Extinguisher/location	Date	Initials	Result and action taken
_____	_____	_____	☐ OK ☐ Service/replace: _____
_____	_____	_____	☐ OK ☐ Service/replace: _____

△ CAUTION — PREVENT HARM

Approval hold: A fire-service professional or other qualified fire-safety subject-matter expert must review this handout before approval.

SOURCES

Sources: U.S. Fire Administration, “Choosing and Using Fire Extinguishers”; National Fire Protection Association, “Fire Extinguishers”; and the product-specific extinguisher label and manufacturer instructions. Accessed 2026-09-29.

Fire Extinguisher Check and Use — continued

Use an extinguisher only on a small, contained fire when everyone else is leaving, emergency services have been called, and you have a clear escape.

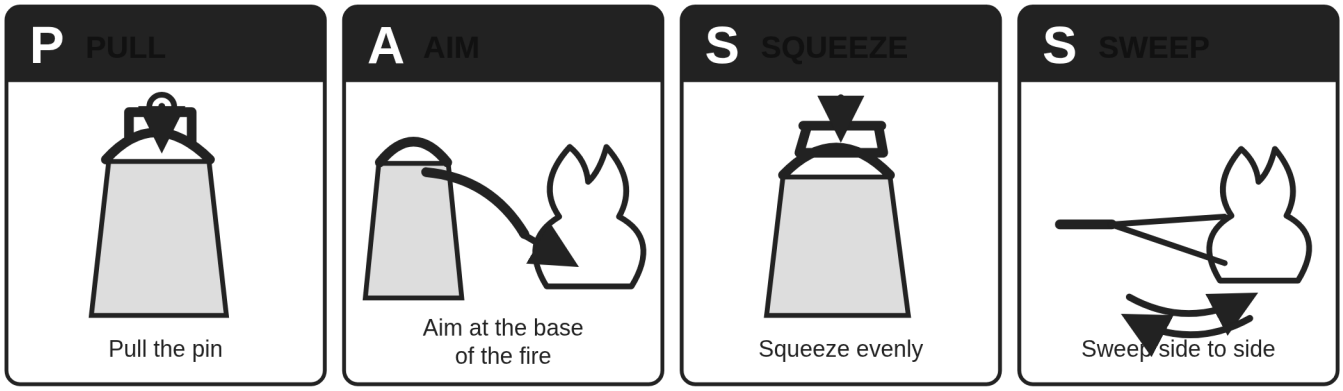
✕ DANGER — STOP NOW

Life safety comes first. Calling emergency services and leaving safely take priority over fighting a fire. If there is any doubt, close the door behind you if you can do so safely, get out, stay out, and call from outside.

BEFORE YOU TRY

Use the extinguisher only if you are trained and **all** of these remain true:

- ☐ The fire is small and contained.
- ☐ Smoke is not affecting visibility or breathing, and heat is not intense.
- ☐ The extinguisher label lists the fire type and you understand its directions.
- ☐ You can keep a clear exit behind you while staying within the label's operating range.



PASS is a memory aid. Use the exact operating directions and distance printed on the extinguisher.
Original Fire Watch diagram; see asset manifest.

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Fire Extinguisher Check and Use — continued

P—A—S—S

1. **PULL** the pin, following the label directions.

2. **AIM** low, at the base of the fire—not at the flames above it.

3. **SQUEEZE** the handle slowly and evenly.

4. **SWEEP** the nozzle from side to side at the base. Watch the area; leave immediately if the fire does not go out or conditions change.

✕ DANGER — STOP NOW

STOP—EVACUATE NOW if the fire is spreading; smoke affects visibility or breathing; heat is intense; the correct extinguisher is unavailable; or the exit cannot remain behind you. Never let fire, smoke, or your attempt to extinguish the fire block your way out.

After any use: get outside, report what happened to responding firefighters, and do not re-enter. Arrange recharge, qualified service, or replacement as the manufacturer directs.

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SOURCES

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